

CASE STUDY

Onboarding for Career-Transitioning Instructional Designers

Role: Instructional designer
Project type: A full needs-analysis-through-evaluation design cycle
Program modeled: 30-day onboarding for teachers moving from the K-12 classroom into corporate L&D
Deliverables: ID Brief · Curriculum Map · Content Storyboard · Evaluation Plan

The Challenge

L&D teams increasingly hire former classroom teachers into instructional design roles, drawn by their strong pedagogical instincts. But most onboarding is built for people who already have corporate context (business KPIs, authoring tools, working through subject-matter experts instead of being the expert) and teachers don't arrive with that context, even though they arrive with most of the underlying skill. Treated as a generic new-hire onboarding problem, the ramp-up is slow: the gap gets mistaken for a skill gap, when it's really a translation gap. I designed this program to close that specific gap, on a fixed 30-day timeline.

My Approach

I started with a needs analysis rather than jumping to content, because the shape of the solution depends entirely on what kind of gap this is. That analysis -documented in the Instructional Design Brief- is what led to the program's central design bet: treat this as a knowledge and context gap, not a remedial skill gap, and build the program around translation and applied practice instead of teaching instructional design from scratch.

- **70-20-10, not a lecture series:** Structured the month around a 70-20-10 model, front-loading formal workshops in Week 1 and shifting to independent, applied project work by Week 4, which mirrors the exact shift a new hire needs to make, from instructor-led classroom habits to self-directed corporate learning.
- **One capstone, not a checklist of modules:** Anchored the second half of the program in one simulated stakeholder project, so that by Day 20 each new hire has a real, portfolio-ready deliverable and not just a completion certificate.
- **Reuse the skill, translate the label:** Built the capstone rubric directly out of the “grading rubric” instinct teachers already have, named explicitly in the gap analysis, rather than inventing new assessment language they'd have to learn from zero.

What I Built

Four connected artifacts, each usable on its own but designed to be read as one project:

Artifact	What It Shows
Instructional Design Brief	The needs analysis: business problem, audience, gap analysis, root cause, and recommended solution that everything else is built from.
Curriculum Map	The full 20-day / 4-week design, color-coded to show the shift from formal instruction toward independent applied work (70-20-10).
Content Storyboard	A worked example of the kind of deliverable a new hire produces in Week 3, a 7-screen script and interaction design for a manager-feedback module.
Evaluation Plan	A Kirkpatrick-based plan, plus a capstone scoring rubric, for judging whether the program actually worked.

Intended Outcome

The design targets, set out in the Evaluation Plan, are: time-to-first-independent-project cut from roughly 16 weeks to roughly 8; every capstone deliverable rated “Proficient” or higher against the rubric without major revision; and rising confidence/independence ratings across the 30/60/90-day manager check-ins that follow the program. Reaction and learning are measured inside the 30 days; behavior and business results are tracked out to 90 days and 6 months, since those effects take longer to surface than the program itself.

Reflection

The ramp-time and rating figures throughout this project are informed assumptions, built for a design exercise, not pulled from a live program. In a real deployment, the first thing I'd do is go back and validate the 16-week baseline against actual historical ramp data before locking in an 8-week target; the design logic holds regardless, but the numbers deserve real evidence before anyone is held to them.

INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN BRIEF

30-Day Onboarding Program for Career-Transitioning Instructional Designers (K-12 Teacher → Corporate L&D)

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Prepared for: L&D Director / Hiring Manager

Date: Aug 6th, 2026

Status: Draft for Stakeholder Review

1. Business Problem

L&D teams increasingly hire former classroom teachers into instructional design and curriculum roles for their strong pedagogical foundation. Yet new hires from education backgrounds typically take 3–4 months to reach full productivity, *nearly double the ramp time of hires with prior corporate ID experience*, because standard onboarding assumes corporate context (business KPIs, SME collaboration, authoring tools) that teachers have not been exposed to. This slows project delivery, increases manager and mentor time investment, and risks early attrition when new hires feel less competent than their underlying skills warrant.

2. Target Audience

Newly hired instructional designers / curriculum developers with 2+ years of K-12 or higher-ed teaching experience and no prior corporate L&D experience. They bring strong skills in lesson design, differentiation, and assessment, but limited exposure to business terminology, authoring software, and stakeholder-driven (rather than standards-driven) design.

3. Gap Analysis

	Current State	Desired State
Vocabulary & Models	Comfortable with lesson planning, standards, and rubrics	Fluent in ADDIE/SAM, performance objectives, and business-aligned design
Tools	Familiar with classroom / EdTech platforms	Proficient in authoring tools (e.g., Storyline, Rise) and project trackers
Working Relationships	Sole content expert in the classroom	Extracts expertise from SMEs; designs for others' content
Success Metrics	Grades, standardized test scores	Business KPIs; Kirkpatrick-based evaluation
Pace & Structure	Semester / bell-schedule rhythm	Sprint-based, deadline-driven project cycles

4. Root Cause

This is primarily a knowledge and context gap, not a skill gap. The core competencies of instructional design are already present; the barrier is unfamiliarity with corporate vocabulary, tools, and working relationships. The solution should therefore focus on translation and applied practice rather than remedial skill-building.

5. Recommended Solution

A 30-day blended onboarding program following a 70-20-10 model: structured skills-translation and tool training in Weeks 1–2, applied project work with stakeholder role-play in Week 3, and a capstone with manager check-in in Week 4. A dedicated peer mentor is assigned for the full 30 days to support the 20% social-learning component.

6. Learning Objectives

By the end of the program, participants will be able to:

- Translate classroom instructional practices into corporate ID vocabulary and models (ADDIE/SAM)
- Conduct a SME interview to extract content for a training deliverable
- Build a training module using the organization's standard authoring tool
- Design a Kirkpatrick-aligned evaluation plan for a learning solution
- Manage a design project against a business timeline and stakeholder expectations

7. Success Metrics

- Time-to-first-independent-project reduced from ~16 weeks to ~8 weeks
- Capstone deliverable meets team quality bar without major revision
- Positive 30/60/90-day manager check-in ratings (confidence, independence)
- Program relevance survey (Kirkpatrick Level 1) averages $\geq 4.5 / 5$

8. Constraints & Assumptions

- One dedicated peer mentor per new hire, available ~3 hours/week
- Access to a real or simulated business project for Week 3–4 practice
- Existing authoring tool licenses in place; no new software procurement
- Fixed 30-calendar-day timeline from start date

9. Key Stakeholders

L&D Director (sponsor) · Hiring Manager · Assigned Peer Mentor · New Hire

CURRICULUM MAP

30-Day Onboarding Program for Career-Transitioning Instructional Designers (K-12 Teacher → Corporate L&D)

This map operationalizes the objectives, gap analysis, and 70-20-10 design model defined in the companion Instructional Design Brief. Each day is tagged by the type of learning experience it delivers, so the shift from formal instruction toward independent, applied work is visible across the month.

How to Read This Map

■ Formal (~10%) — Workshop / Orientation / Setup ■ Social (~20%) — Mentor / Check-in ■ Experiential (~70%) — Practice / Role-Play ■ Milestone — Capstone checkpoint

Program at a Glance

Week	Theme	Goal	Maps to	Checkpoint
Week 1	Reframe — You Already Know More Than You Think	Orient to team and culture; translate existing teaching skills into ID vocabulary; establish the mentor relationship.	LO1	Skills Bridge map completed
Week 2	Tools & Models — The New Toolkit	Build hands-on fluency with the authoring tool, core ID models, and SME collaboration.	LO1–LO3	Storyboard outline drafted (seeds capstone)
Week 3	Applied Practice — Design in Action	Run one full design cycle — kickoff through draft — with stakeholder role-play and evaluation design.	LO2–LO5	First full capstone draft complete
Week 4	Integration — Owning the Work	Finalize and present the capstone; self-assess against the ID competency framework; set a forward trajectory.	LO3–LO5	Capstone presented; 30/60/90 plan set

WEEK 1: Reframe - You Already Know More Than You Think

Week goal: Orient to team and culture; translate existing teaching skills into ID vocabulary; establish the mentor relationship.

Maps to objectives: LO1

Day	Session Focus	Activities	Deliverable
Day 1 (Mon)	Welcome & Orientation	[Orientation] Meet the team, org-chart walkthrough, and intro to the L&D function's role in the business [Setup] Provision LMS, authoring tool, and project-tracker accounts	Completed account-setup checklist
Day 2 (Tue)	Andragogy Foundations	[Workshop] Andragogy vs. pedagogy: how adult learners in a workplace differ from students in a classroom [Mentor] First 1:1 with assigned peer mentor	Reflection — 3 ways adult learners differ from your former students
Day 3 (Wed)	Skills-Translation Workshop, Part 1	[Workshop] Map teaching competencies to the ID competency framework (lesson planning → needs analysis; differentiation → learner personas; rubrics → assessment design)	Draft “Skills Bridge” map (in progress)
Day 4 (Thu)	Skills-Translation Workshop, Part 2 & ID Vocabulary	[Workshop] Glossary walkthrough: SME, stakeholder, KPI, performance objective vs. standard [Practice] Rewrite 3 former lesson objectives as performance-based objectives	Completed “Skills Bridge” one-pager
Day 5 (Fri)	Week 1 Wrap	[Mentor] Mentor check-in — review Skills Bridge map together [Check-in] Manager check-in — Week 1 debrief	Skills Bridge map submitted to manager

WEEK 2: Tools & Models - The New Toolkit

Week goal: Build hands-on fluency with the authoring tool, core ID models, and SME collaboration.

Maps to objectives: LO1, LO2, LO3

Day	Session Focus	Activities	Deliverable
Day 6 (Mon)	ADDIE / SAM Deep Dive	[Workshop] Compare ADDIE and SAM to backward design — a model already familiar from teaching	Model-comparison chart
Day 7 (Tue)	Authoring Tool Bootcamp, Part 1	[Workshop] Guided walkthrough of the org's authoring tool — navigation and basic interactions [Practice] Build one interactive practice screen	First interactive screen
Day 8 (Wed)	Authoring Tool Bootcamp, Part 2	[Practice] Independent build: a 3-screen mini-module	3-screen practice module
Day 9 (Thu)	Working with SMEs	[Workshop] SME interview technique: extracting expertise vs. being the expert [Role-Play] Mock SME interview with a colleague playing a business SME with a vague request	SME interview notes + content outline
Day 10 (Fri)	Week 2 Wrap & Storyboarding	[Workshop] Storyboarding conventions and templates [Mentor] Mentor review of the Week 2 practice module	Storyboard outline for a simulated business request (seeds Week 3 project)

WEEK 3: Applied Practice - Design in Action

Week goal: Run one full design cycle (*kickoff through draft*) with stakeholder role-play and evaluation design.

Maps to objectives: LO2, LO3, LO4, LO5

Day	Session Focus	Activities	Deliverable
Day 11 (Mon)	Project Kickoff	[Role-Play] Simulated stakeholder kickoff with a business sponsor giving vague, shifting requirements	Project charter / scope note
Day 12 (Tue)	Needs Analysis & Design Plan	[Practice] Apply needs-analysis skills to the simulated project	Mini needs-analysis + design plan
Day 13 (Wed)	Build Sprint, Part 1	[Practice] Draft the module in the authoring tool [Mentor] Peer design review with mentor	Working draft (screens 1–5)
Day 14 (Thu)	Evaluation Design	[Workshop] Kirkpatrick's four levels of evaluation [Practice] Draft an evaluation plan for the mini-project	Evaluation plan
Day 15 (Fri)	Build Sprint, Part 2 & Week 3 Wrap	[Practice] Incorporate mentor feedback; complete first full draft	First full capstone draft

WEEK 4: Integration - Owning the Work

Week goal: Finalize and present the capstone; self-assess against the ID competency framework; set a forward trajectory.

Maps to objectives: LO3, LO4, LO5

Day	Session Focus	Activities	Deliverable
Day 16 (Mon)	Revision Sprint	[Practice] Revise capstone based on Week 3 feedback	Revised capstone draft
Day 17 (Tue)	Peer Review & Polish	[Mentor] Cross-review with another new hire or teammate [Practice] Final polish pass	Polished capstone module
Day 18 (Wed)	Presentation Prep	[Workshop] Presenting to stakeholders — translating “parent-night” presence into a business setting	Presentation outline
Day 19 (Thu)	Capstone Presentation	[Milestone] Present capstone to team and manager	Capstone delivered
Day 20 (Fri)	Self-Assessment & Forward Plan	[Workshop] Self-assessment against the Week 1 ID competency framework [Check-in] Manager 1:1 — set 30/60/90-day goals	Completed self-assessment + 30/60/90 plan

CONTENT STORYBOARD

Week 3 Capstone Practice Project: Giving Effective Feedback: A Guide for New Managers

This is the sample deliverable a new hire produces during Week 3 (Days 11–15) of the onboarding program: a full content storyboard built from the simulated stakeholder kickoff, then handed off for build in the authoring tool. It is evaluated against the objectives and competency framework defined in the companion Instructional Design Brief.

Project Snapshot

Course title: Giving Effective Feedback: A Guide for New Managers

Target audience: Newly promoted people managers (0–6 months in role)

Modality & length: Self-paced e-learning · ~15 minutes · 7 screens

Terminal objective: Given a workplace scenario, the learner will draft feedback that correctly applies the Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) model.

Simulated stakeholder: VP of People Operations (role-played by mentor, per Day 11 kickoff)

Maps to onboarding objectives: LO2 (SME interview → content extraction), LO3 (build in authoring tool)

Storyboard format: Content storyboard (script + interaction logic). Visual mockups are produced separately in the authoring tool build phase.

Version / status: v1 - Draft for mentor review (Day 13 checkpoint)

Giving Effective Feedback: Screen-by-Screen Storyboard

Screen	Visual & Layout	On-Screen Text	Narration Script	Interactivity & Notes
Screen 1 <i>Title & Welcome</i>	Full-bleed photo background: two colleagues in a warm, informal conversation. Course title centered, mid-screen. Team/org logo, top left. "Begin" button, bottom right.	Giving Effective Feedback: A Guide for New Managers 15 minutes · Estimated completion [Begin]	<i>"Feedback is one of the most powerful tools you have as a new manager, and one of the easiest to get wrong. In the next fifteen minutes, you'll learn a simple framework for giving feedback that's clear, specific, and actually helps people improve."</i>	Type: Static, auto-play narration Nav: Single click on Begin to advance
Screen 2 <i>Meet the Scenario</i>	Split-screen illustration: manager character "Jordan" (left) and direct report "Alex" (right). Thought bubble above Jordan suggesting hesitation.	Alex has missed two project deadlines this month. Jordan needs to say something, but isn't sure how to start the conversation without it feeling like a lecture, or letting it turn into conflict.	<i>"Meet Jordan, a new manager. One of Jordan's team members, Alex, has missed two deadlines this month. Jordan knows a conversation is overdue, but isn't sure how to bring it up without sounding harsh, or worse, avoiding the issue altogether. Sound familiar?"</i>	Type: Static, auto-play narration Nav: Next button
Screen 3 <i>Introducing the SBI Model</i>	Three circles labeled S / B / I, connected by arrows left to right. Each circle animates in on click, revealing an icon and short definition.	SITUATION - When and where it happened. BEHAVIOR - What you specifically observed. IMPACT - The effect it had.	<i>"The SBI model breaks feedback into three simple parts. Situation: name the specific moment or context. Behavior: describe exactly what you observed, not your interpretation of it. Impact: explain the effect that behavior had, on the team, the project, or the business."</i>	Type: Click-to-reveal (guided discovery) Rule: Next is disabled until all 3 circles are opened
Screen 4 <i>Try It, Apply SBI to Jordan's Situation</i>	Drag-and-drop layout. Three labeled drop zones (Situation / Behavior / Impact) across the top. Three draggable text tiles below, presented in scrambled order.	Tiles: "In yesterday's status meeting..." / "...you said the report was on track, but it wasn't submitted." / "...the client team had to delay their own deliverable." On correct sort: "That's it. Notice each piece describes something specific and observable, not a judgment about Alex's character or effort."	<i>"Now you try. Drag each sentence into the part of the SBI model it belongs to."</i>	Type: Drag-and-drop knowledge check Feedback: Incorrect tile returns with a gentle shake + hint text Rule: All 3 correct to unlock Next
Screen 5 <i>Common Pitfalls to Avoid</i>	Tabbed panel, 3 tabs across the top: "Waiting too long," "Making it personal," "Skipping the impact." Each tab reveals a short scenario snippet below.	Tab 1: "Waiting too long turns feedback into an ambush." Tab 2: "'You're careless' is a judgment, not a behavior." Tab 3: "Without impact, feedback feels arbitrary."	<i>"Even with a good framework, feedback can go wrong. Explore three of the most common pitfalls, and what to do instead."</i>	Type: Tabbed exploration Rule: Learner must open at least 2 of 3 tabs to enable Next Tracking: Each tab open logged for completion reporting
Screen 6 <i>Knowledge Check</i>	Scenario text box at top. Four answer options below, presented as selectable cards (A–D).	Alex arrives 15 minutes late to three meetings this week. Which response best follows the SBI model? A) "You're always late, it's disrespectful." B) "In this week's three team meetings, you arrived about 15 minutes after the start time, which meant we had to recap material and pushed our agenda over."	<i>"Let's check your understanding before you go. Choose the response that best follows the SBI model."</i>	Type: Single-select multiple choice Correct: B Feedback: A = judgment, not behavior; C = vague, no SBI structure; D = hearsay, not directly observed Rule: Retry allowed; must select B to proceed

Screen	Visual & Layout	On-Screen Text	Narration Script	Interactivity & Notes
		C) "Try to be more punctual going forward." D) "Everyone's noticed you're always late."		
Screen 7 <i>Summary & Resources</i>	Clean recap layout. Small S / B / I icon set from Screen 3 repeated at top. Checklist-style bullet summary. "Download the SBI Conversation Guide (PDF)" button. "Finish" button.	You've learned how to structure feedback using Situation, Behavior, and Impact. Before your next feedback conversation, try drafting your own SBI statement using the guide below. [Download Guide (PDF)] [Finish]	<i>"Nice work. You now have a simple structure for feedback conversations: Situation, Behavior, Impact. Download the quick-reference guide below, and try using SBI the next time you need to give feedback, starting, maybe, with Jordan's conversation with Alex."</i>	Type: Resource download + completion Nav: PDF opens in new tab; Finish marks module complete in LMS

EVALUATION PLAN

30-Day Onboarding Program for Career-Transitioning Instructional Designers (K-12 Teacher → Corporate L&D)

This plan operationalizes the success metrics defined in Section 7 of the companion Instructional Design Brief, using Kirkpatrick's four-level model. It specifies, for each level, what question is being answered, how the data is collected, when, against what target, and who owns it, so the program's impact can be judged on evidence rather than completion alone.

Four-Level Evaluation Plan

Level	Evaluation Question	Method & Instrument	Timing	Success Target	Owner
1 / Reaction	Did participants find the onboarding relevant, engaging, and appropriately paced?	Post-program survey (5-point Likert + open comments); weekly 1-question pulse check at the close of each week	Weekly pulses; full survey Day 20	Average relevance rating ≥ 4.5 / 5; ≥ 90% survey completion	L&D Program Coordinator
2 / Learning	Did participants gain the target ID knowledge, skills, and confidence (LO1–LO5)?	Capstone deliverable scored against the rubric below; Day 5 Skills Bridge map compared to Day 20 self-assessment as a growth marker	Rubric scoring Day 19–20	Capstone rated “Proficient” or higher on all 5 criteria without major revision	Manager + assigned mentor
3 / Behavior	Are new hires applying ID skills independently on real projects after onboarding ends?	Structured manager check-ins (confidence, independence, quality ratings); mentor observation notes on the first 2 independent projects	Day 30 / 60 / 90 post-start	Ratings trend upward across the 3 check-ins; less support needed by Day 60	Hiring manager
4 / Results	Did the program reduce ramp time and improve business outcomes?	Time-to-first-independent-project tracked in the project system; 6-month retention vs. historical baseline; brief stakeholder interviews on training quality	Ongoing; formal review at 6 months	Time-to-independent-project down from ~16 to ~8 weeks; 6-month retention ≥ baseline	L&D Director (sponsor)

Capstone Scoring Rubric (Level 2 Detail)

Used by the manager and mentor to score the Week 4 capstone deliverable against each of the five onboarding objectives. A rating of “Proficient” or higher on all five criteria satisfies the Level 2 target above.

Criterion	Emerging	Developing	Proficient	Exemplary
Translates teaching practice into ID vocabulary & models (LO1)	Uses classroom terms with no corporate equivalent	Uses ID terms inconsistently or imprecisely	Applies ADDIE/SAM and performance-objective language accurately	Fluently translates between both vocabularies; coaches peers
Extracts and organizes content from a SME (LO2)	Relies on own assumptions over SME input	Gathers SME input but content stays disorganized	Interview yields a clear, well-organized content outline	Anticipates gaps and proactively follows up with the SME
Builds a functional module in the authoring tool (LO3)	Struggles with basic tool navigation	Builds functional screens with some technical errors	Builds a polished, error-free module independently	Builds efficiently and troubleshoots issues without support
Designs a Kirkpatrick-aligned evaluation plan (LO4)	Plan addresses reaction only	Plan addresses 2 of 4 levels	Plan addresses all 4 levels with reasonable methods	Plan ties methods to specific, measurable business outcomes
Manages the project against a timeline & stakeholder expectations (LO5)	Misses deadlines; needs frequent redirection	Meets most deadlines with reminders	Meets all deadlines; manages scope changes independently	Proactively communicates risk and renegotiates scope

Data Collection Timeline

- End of Weeks 1–4: one-question pulse check (reaction)
- Day 5: Skills Bridge map captured as the pre-program learning baseline
- Day 19–20: capstone rubric scoring and self-assessment (learning)
- Day 20: full program relevance survey (reaction)
- Day 30 / 60 / 90: structured manager check-ins (behavior)
- 6 months: retention and time-to-independent-project review (results)